India's Freedom Struggle: Key Movements

Introduction

India's freedom struggle was the long movement, lasting about 90 years if one counts from the Revolt of 1857, to end British colonial rule. The British East India Company gained control of large parts of India after the Battle of Plassey in 1757 and the Battle of Buxar in 1764, and after 1858 the British Crown ruled India directly. The struggle took many forms: armed rebellions, petitions, mass non-violent movements, revolutionary actions and political negotiation. Millions of Indians from every region and religion took part, and many sacrificed their lives.

Early Phase

The Revolt of 1857, started by sepoys at Meerut on 10 May 1857, is often called the First War of Independence, with leaders such as Rani Lakshmibai of Jhansi, Tantia Tope, Nana Sahib and Bahadur Shah Zafar. Earlier, Tamil Nadu saw resistance by Puli Thevar, Rani Velu Nachiyar of Sivaganga, who became the first queen to fight the British in India in the 1780s, Veerapandiya Kattabomman, the Maruthu brothers and the Vellore Mutiny of 1806. The Indian National Congress was founded on 28 December 1885 in Bombay, with A. O. Hume as an organiser and W. C. Bonnerjee as the first president. The Partition of Bengal in 1905 by Lord Curzon led to the Swadeshi and Boycott movement. In Tamil Nadu, V. O. Chidambaram Pillai launched the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company in Tuticorin in 1906, and the poet Subramania Bharati inspired people with patriotic songs. The extremist leaders Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Bipin Chandra Pal and Lala Lajpat Rai demanded "Swaraj".

The Gandhian Era

Mahatma Gandhi returned from South Africa in 1915 and led movements at Champaran in 1917, Kheda and Ahmedabad. The Rowlatt Act of 1919 allowed detention without trial, and on 13 April 1919 British troops under General Dyer fired on a peaceful crowd at Jallianwala Bagh in Amritsar, killing hundreds. The Non-Cooperation Movement, 1920 to 1922, asked Indians to boycott British goods, schools and courts, and was called off after the violence at Chauri Chaura in February 1922. In December 1929 the Congress at Lahore, under Jawaharlal Nehru, demanded Purna Swaraj, complete independence, and 26 January 1930 was observed as Independence Day.

What Was the Salt March?

The Salt March, also known as the Dandi March, was a landmark act of non-violent civil disobedience led by Mahatma Gandhi in 1930 against the British salt tax and monopoly. The British law made it illegal for Indians to make or sell salt, and the tax affected the poor most. On 12 March 1930, Gandhi and 78 followers began walking from the Sabarmati Ashram near Ahmedabad toward the coastal village of Dandi in Gujarat, a distance of about 240 miles (nearly 390 kilometres). The march lasted 24 days, and thousands joined along the way. On 6 April 1930, Gandhi picked up a lump of natural salt on the beach at Dandi, breaking the salt law. This began the Civil Disobedience Movement, and thousands across India made salt, were arrested and joined boycotts. In Tamil Nadu, C. Rajagopalachari led a similar march from Tiruchirappalli to Vedaranyam in April 1930. The Salt March attracted worldwide attention and showed the power of non-violent protest.

What Was the Quit India Movement?

The Quit India Movement, also called the August Movement or August Kranti, was launched on 8 August 1942 by Mahatma Gandhi at the Bombay session of the All India Congress Committee at Gowalia Tank Maidan, now called August Kranti Maidan. Gandhi gave the call "Do or Die", demanding an immediate end to British rule. The British arrested Gandhi, Nehru, Patel and other leaders in the early hours of 9 August 1942, so the movement spread without leadership as a spontaneous mass uprising, with strikes, protests and sabotage. Leaders such as Aruna Asaf Ali, Jayaprakash Narayan and Usha Mehta, who ran a secret Congress Radio, kept the movement alive. The British crushed it by force, but it made clear that British rule in India could not continue. The Quit India Movement is widely seen as the final major push before independence, and 9 August is remembered as Quit India Day.

Other Streams of the Struggle

Revolutionaries such as Bhagat Singh, Chandrashekhar Azad, Sukhdev and Rajguru, Khudiram Bose and Surya Sen used armed resistance. Subhas Chandra Bose formed the Indian National Army (Azad Hind Fauj) with the slogan "Dilli Chalo" and allied with Japan during World War II. Dr. B. R. Ambedkar fought for the rights of the oppressed. Women such as Sarojini Naidu, Annie Besant, Kasturba Gandhi, Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay and Tamil Nadu's Rukmini Lakshmipathi took leading roles.

What Happened on 15 August 1947?

On 15 August 1947, India became independent from British rule. The Indian Independence Act of 1947, passed by the British Parliament, divided British India into two independent dominions, India and Pakistan. At the stroke of midnight on 14 August, Jawaharlal Nehru gave his famous "Tryst with Destiny" speech in the Constituent Assembly, and on 15 August he hoisted the national flag at the Red Fort in Delhi, becoming the first Prime Minister of independent India, with Lord Mountbatten as the first Governor-General. The joy of freedom was overshadowed by the pain of Partition, which caused massive violence and the migration of millions of people. Mahatma Gandhi, who spent the day fasting and praying in Calcutta, was assassinated on 30 January 1948. India celebrates 15 August as Independence Day each year, with the Prime Minister's speech at the Red Fort.

Legacy

The freedom struggle gave India its democratic and secular values and the constitution of 1950. It inspired anti-colonial movements in Asia and Africa.

Quick Facts

- The Salt March began on 12 March 1930 from Sabarmati Ashram and ended at Dandi on 6 April 1930.
- The Quit India Movement was launched on 8 August 1942 with Gandhi's call "Do or Die".
- India became independent on 15 August 1947; Nehru was the first Prime Minister.
- The Indian National Congress was founded on 28 December 1885.
- Rajaji led the Vedaranyam salt march in Tamil Nadu in April 1930.